Macaurog B. Derogongan

Dr. Macaurog B. Derogongan is a prominent Filipino academic, agricultural scientist, and university administrator. He is widely recognized for his foundational role in expanding the Mindanao State University (MSU) system, particularly serving as the first head of what would become MSU-Maguindanao, and later leading the academic arm of the entire MSU system during a transformative era in the late 1980s.

Dr. Macaurog B. Derogongan	
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Born	Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Meranao
Alma mater	Mindanao State University
Discipline	Agricultural Sciences
Institution	Mindanao State University (MSU System)
Main campus	MSU Main Campus (Marawi)
Notable Positions	
• Founding Director, MSU-DATC (1973–1974) • Dean, MSU College of Agriculture (1976–1977) • Acting Vice President for Academic Affairs (1989)	
Known For	
Pioneering development of MSU-Maguindanao; landmark inclusion in Philippine jurisprudence	

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Early Life and Cultural Roots

Macaurog B. Derogongan was born and raised in the province of Lanao del Sur, Philippines, growing up immersed in the traditional, deeply faithful culture of the Meranao (*people of the lake*). Coming of age in a society that places immense value on both customary ancestral lineage and Islamic scholarship, Derogongan recognized early on that access to higher education would be the most powerful tool to uplift his community.

Choosing to specialize in the agricultural sciences, he dedicated his early academic career to studying sustainable farming methods. His goal was to address a vital, practical need in the region: harnessing the fertile, rolling terrains of Mindanao to ensure food security and economic self-reliance for local communities.

Academic Career and Institutional Contributions

Founding Leadership at MSU-Maguindanao (1973–1974)

By the early 1970s, the Mindanao State University system was actively seeking ways to foster regional integration and peace through educational expansion. On October 10, 1973, the MSU Board of Regents passed **BOR Resolution No. 821, series of 1973**, establishing a specialized branch in Dinaig (now Datu Odin Sinsuat), Maguindanao.

Then known as the **MSU-Dinaig Agricultural and Technical College (MSU-DATC)**, the fledgling institution required an organized leader to build its foundations from the ground up. Dr. Derogongan was appointed as its **founding Director**, serving from 1973 to 1974. Operating on a shoestring budget during the second semester of that academic year, he managed a tiny staff consisting of:

- Seven (7) faculty members
- Fifteen (15) administrative employees
- One hundred and twenty-six (126) pioneering students

Despite these humble beginnings, the structural and academic framework laid down by Derogongan served as the baseline blueprint for what has now evolved into the fully-fledged **MSU-Maguindanao** campus.

Dean of the College of Agriculture (1976–1977)

Following his foundational work in Maguindanao, Dr. Derogongan returned to the MSU Main Campus in Marawi City. By the 1976–1977 academic year, he was appointed **Dean of the College of Agriculture**.

Serving alongside historic MSU figures—such as Acting Officer-in-Charge Mohamad-Ali Dimaporo and Vice President for Academic Affairs Emily M. Marohombsar—Dean Derogongan shifted the college's focus toward community-driven instruction. He realigned academic research with the real-world economic realities of local farmers, transforming the college into an active engine for regional agricultural development rather than an isolated ivory tower.

System Vice Presidency and Jurisprudential Footprint (1989)

By the late 1980s, Dr. Derogongan’s extensive administrative track record elevated him to the university system's executive branch. In 1989, under **Special Order No. 04-P, S. 1989**, he was designated as the **Acting Vice President for Academic Affairs** for the entire MSU System.

This particular chapter of leadership unexpectedly placed Dr. Derogongan at the center of a landmark legal battle regarding university autonomy and state civil service regulations. A dispute over executive authority and shifting university appointments culminated in the historic Philippine Supreme Court case ***Marohombsar vs. Alonto, Jr. (G.R. No. 93711)***, decided on February 25, 1991. While the case fundamentally centered on the legality of administrative designations, the official inclusion of Dr. Derogongan's appointment in the High Court's records permanently etched his name into the legal history of public education management in the Philippines.

Cultural Significance and Legacy

Dr. Derogongan belongs to a pioneering generation of Bangsamoro intellectuals who successfully bridged traditional Meranao society with modern, secular academic governance. During a highly volatile sociopolitical era in modern Mindanao history, he weaponized education as a stabilizing force for peace.

His efforts helped transition MSU from a solitary provincial campus into a vast, decentralized university system that continues to educate and empower thousands of youth across the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM). Decades later, his lineage of public service remains deeply felt in the region, with members of the Derogongan family continuing to lead in higher education administration and local civic development across Lanao.

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- Mindanao State University–Maguindanao
- Maranao people

References

- Supreme Court of the Philippines. (1991). *Emily M. Marohombsar vs. Ahmad E. Alonto, Jr., et al. (G.R. No. 93711)*.
- Mindanao State University Main Campus Official Governance Archives.
- MSU-Maguindanao Institutional History Records (BOR Resolution No. 821, Series of 1973).

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